



Lazulite

△ **Single, dipyramidal crystal** of lazulite from Afghanistan

lazulite takes its name from the old German word *lazurstein*, meaning “blue stone”. It is usually azure blue, sky blue, bluish white, or blue green. Rare faceting material is sometimes found, which can appear blue or white, depending on the angle it is viewed from. Granular lazulite is cut *en cabochon*, and can be tumble polished; it is sometimes fashioned into beads and carved into artefacts. Its appearance can be similar to lapis lazuli (see pp.174–77), and it is sometimes confused with lazurite (the main component of lapis lazuli) or azurite.

Specification

Chemical name Magnesium aluminium phosphate | **Formula** $(\text{Mg,Fe})\text{Al}_2(\text{PO}_4)_2(\text{OH})_2$ | **Colours** Various shades of blue
Structure Monoclinic | **Hardness** 5–6 | **SG** 3.1 | **RI** 1.61–1.64 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White | **Locations** Sweden, Austria, Switzerland, Canada, USA, Afghanistan

Mottled colouring



Lazulite on muscovite | Rough | This specimen displays intensely coloured lazulite crystals encrusting muscovite mica, accompanied by pink feldspar.

Dazzling blue crystals

Lazulite in quartz mass



Crystals in matrix | Rough | Afghanistan has produced some of the finest crystals of lazulite ever found, such as these specimens in a matrix of quartz.



A single crystal | Rough | This finely-formed single crystal of lazulite in quartz from Afghanistan features a perfect dipyramidal form.



Lazurite | Rough | The intense blue colour displayed in this example of lazurite rough from Chile reveals how easily it can be confused with lazulite.



Cabochon | Cut | A typically mottled blue appearance is enhanced by this low-domed cut *en cabochon*, which also shows off the stone's vitreous lustre.